

Leighton Van Ness

AI Operations, Implementation & Customer-Facing Systems Lead

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SUMMARY

AI operations, implementation, sales-enablement, and customer-facing systems leader who builds internal tools, operational platforms, GTM workflows, and AI-enabled processes. Partner with sales teams and customers to translate business needs into practical systems and dependable delivery across CRM workflows, client programs, event operations, and post-sale execution. Bring hands-on technical fluency across APIs, modern web platforms, CRM systems, analytics, and deployment workflows.

EXPERIENCE

Elevate Experiences | VP, Innovation

New York, NY | 2024 - Present

- Built and manage the Elevate Dashboard, a shared operations platform for event planning, ticketing, user administration, vendor and talent coordination, and production management.
- Developed the platform with React, serverless Node.js APIs, Redis/Upstash, Google Sheets integrations, and role-based access controls on Vercel.
- Established CI/CD, preview deployments, automated tests, production safeguards, PDF/Word exports, and recurring release verification.
- Lead AI and workflow implementation, evaluating tools, piloting practical use cases, and helping teams apply AI systems to operating workflows.
- Built a custom, end-to-end AI sales agent using ChatGPT, Instantly, MailerLite, APIs, and multi-domain email infrastructure to automatically build targeted prospect lists, research and qualify leads, personalize and run cold-outreach sequences, manage sending operations, and synchronize lead and engagement data with CRM workflows.
- Serve as a customer-facing technical and operations lead for approximately 25 virtual events annually and 5-10 private concerts and large-format experiences, working directly with clients and coordinating back-end execution across talent, vendors, logistics, and production teams.
- Led the Elevate Experiences website launch and now manage SEO, analytics, content, inquiry flows, and HubSpot- and Salesforce-connected workflows that support sales handoffs and customer delivery.
- Built an automated logistics tracker supporting approximately 60 events, 600 shipped bins, and 12,000-24,000 items with status syncing, alerts, routing, and recovery workflows.

Zinc Agency | VP, Innovation & Technology

New York, NY | 2020 - 2024

- Led the company's pivot to virtual programming during COVID, building the technical platform that preserved service delivery and expanded virtual event offerings.
- Implemented Hive as the division's core project management system, creating custom workflows, forms, automations, and Salesforce-connected operating structure still used across Zinc Agency and Elevate Experiences.
- Engineered a custom streaming and registration platform using WordPress, JavaScript, web APIs, embedded meeting tools, and reusable branded event workflows.
- Supported more than 2,000 celebrity-led livestreams, working directly with corporate clients to translate program goals into technical specifications and coordinating talent, platform, production, and operational stakeholders through delivery.
- Repurposed the platform into InviteMeNow, a customizable registration system for in-person, virtual, and hybrid client experiences.

Zinc Agency | Director of Products

New York, NY | 2018 - 2020

- Led budget creation, experience pricing, product packaging, and sales strategy for premium entertainment and experiential offerings.
- Managed contracts, legal agreements, talent and venue requirements, and critical coordination among artists, representatives, and event stakeholders.

Creative Artists Agency | Account Executive

New York, NY | 2014 - 2018

- Worked directly with corporate buyers to develop talent-led experiential concepts, then coordinated the agency, venue, transportation, concierge, and production requirements needed to deliver sold programs successfully.
- Managed client communication and cross-functional execution throughout planning and delivery for premium corporate programs.

TECHNICAL & AI SKILLS

AI & Automation: ChatGPT, AI agents, sales prospecting automation, prompt/workflow design, research automation, API integrations, Apps Script, Zapier

Platforms & GTM Systems: Salesforce, HubSpot, ZoomInfo, Outreach, Instantly, MailerLite, multi-domain email infrastructure, Google Analytics, SEO, Google Sheets

Product Engineering: JavaScript, TypeScript, React, Node.js, Express, REST APIs, GraphQL, Redis, MongoDB, MySQL, Sanity

Delivery & Quality: Vercel, Netlify, Render, GitHub, CI/CD, Playwright, Jest, auth and permissions, deployment verification, PDF/Word exports

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

CU Boulder - M.S. Computer Science, Estimated Completion 2026

New York University - Management, 2011 - 2013

University of St. Andrews - Economics, 2009 - 2011

Columbia Engineering Coding Boot Camp Professional Certificate, 2024

IBM Full Stack Software Developer Professional Certificate, 2023